

## **Approaches to Course Design in ESP**

### **Introduction**

Designing an ESP course requires careful planning and understanding of learners' goals, backgrounds, and target situations. Different approaches to course design offer various ways to organize content, select materials and plan learning activities. Some approaches focus on learners' needs, others on language skills and some on tasks or real-world performance.

### **1. Definition**

ESP course design is “the process by which the raw data about a learning need is interpreted in order to produce an integrated series of teaching-learning experiences, whose ultimate aim is to lead the learners to a particular state of knowledge” (Hutchinson & waters, 1987, p.65). It is a process of collecting data to prepare effective tasks and activities and to create the most appropriate context for ESP learners to achieve their goals. Course design focuses on closing the gap between existing and desired linguistic proficiency and is guided by a careful needs analysis.

### **2. Approaches to Course Design**

Hutchinson and Waters (1987) identify three main approaches to ESP course design: language-centred, learning-centred and skills-centred.

#### **2.1. Language-Centred Approach**

Those courses are characterized by a direct connection between the target situation and the content of the ESP course. It usually starts from the identification of the linguistic features of the target situation in order to describe the students' needs and to create a syllabus and evaluation procedures after the course materials are designed. Without declining the obvious positive aspects of the language-centred approach to course design, it had been proven to be significantly less adequate for the following reasons:

- ✓ The only aspect in relationship to which the learner is taken into consideration is the identification of the target situation;
- ✓ The assumption that the systematic analysis and presentation of linguistic data characterizing a certain type of specialized discourse will produce systematic learning in the learner. (Bastrurkmen, 2010, p.59);

- ✓ The language centred analysis of target situation data is only at the surface level. It reveals very little about the competence that underlies the performance.

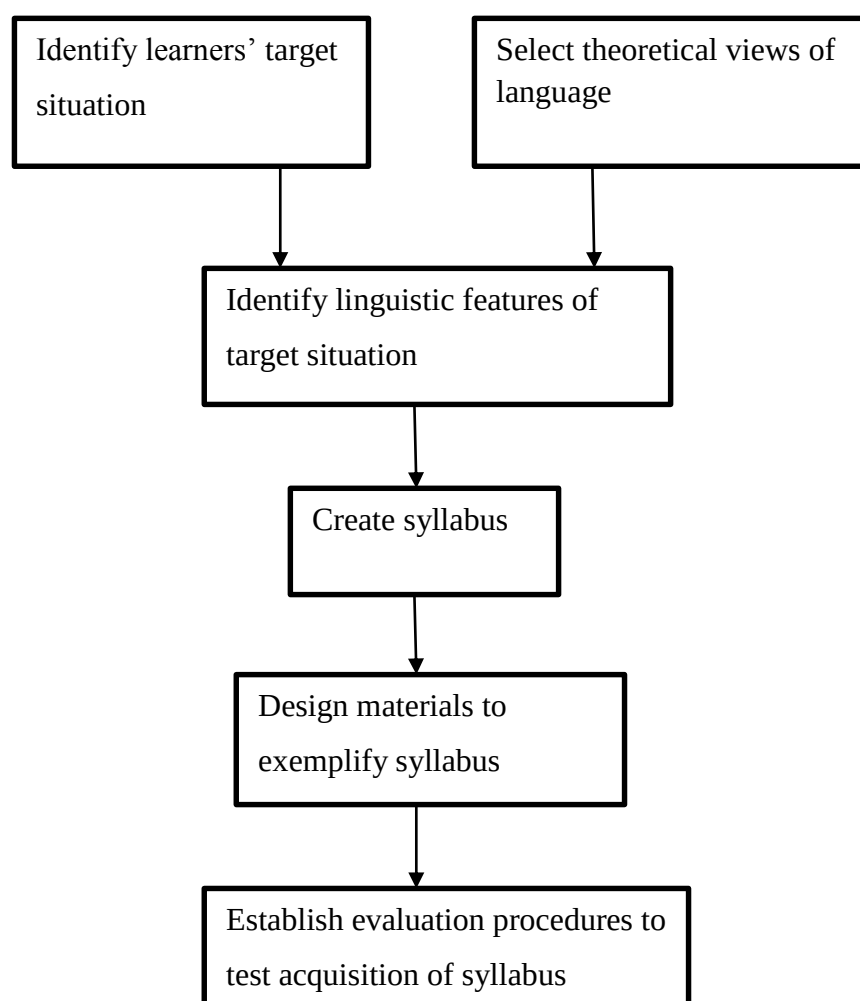


Figure 1: Language-centred approach

## 2.2. Learning-Centred Approach

This approach starts from the assumption that the learner is the most important factor in the learning process, or to put it differently, it is based on the principle that learning is totally determined by the learner who uses his knowledge and skills to process new information. This type of approach takes into account more complex factors, such as the principle that learning is not just a mental process, but also a process of negotiation between individuals and society, in which both the target situation and the learner's level of linguistic competence influence the features of the course. We believe it is important to discuss Hutchinson and Waters' (1987, p.72) distinction between the learning-centred and learner-centred approaches. They prefer the concept of learning-centred course design in order to suggest that this type of approach is focused and tailored on students needs.

### **2.3. Skills-Centred Approach**

This approach focuses on the development of skills, competencies and strategies that are presumably used in the workplace and may be reproduced in real life, the latter is based on the theoretical hypothesis that underling any language behaviour there are certain skills and strategies, which the learner uses in order to produce or comprehend discourse (Creswell, 2003, p.124). Besides, there is a pragmatic basis for the skills-centred approach derived from an important distinction made by Widdowson (1981, p.257) between goal-oriented courses and process-oriented courses. The skills-centred approach to course design views language in terms of how the mind of the learner processes it rather than as an entity in itself and approaches the learner as a user of language rather than as a learner of language.

### **2.4 The Multi-Levelled Approach**

Researchers in the field have sought to look for a methodology by which teachers teach less and learners learn more proving that current problems in the field of ESP are results of faulty teaching that does not necessarily and exclusively meet the requirements of the course objectives. An integration of the previously mentioned approaches namely language-centred learning, skills-centred leaning and learning-centred approach is based on the belief that if all approaches are considered and combined together throughout lesson planning and syllabus design, students on the other end would not find difficulty in maximizing their needs and aspirations vis-à-vis their future endeavours either academically or vocationally.

### **Conclusion**

In ESP course design, there is no single best approach. Each approach offers useful ideas and tools for organising a course and teachers often combine elements from different approaches to meet their learners' needs. Successful course design ensures that learners are well-prepared to use English effectively in their specific fields.